

Study of Current Meeting Scheduling Solutions

Documenting features, strengths, weaknesses, and opportunities for our platform

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1. Scope & Methodology

Four widely used meeting scheduling tools were studied: **Calendly**, **Cal.com**, **Doodle**, and **When2meet**. These were selected because they represent four distinct product philosophies in the space;

- Automation-first individual scheduling (Calendly)
- Open-source API-first infrastructure (Cal.com)
- Group availability polling (Doodle)
- Ultra-minimalist no-account coordination (When2meet).

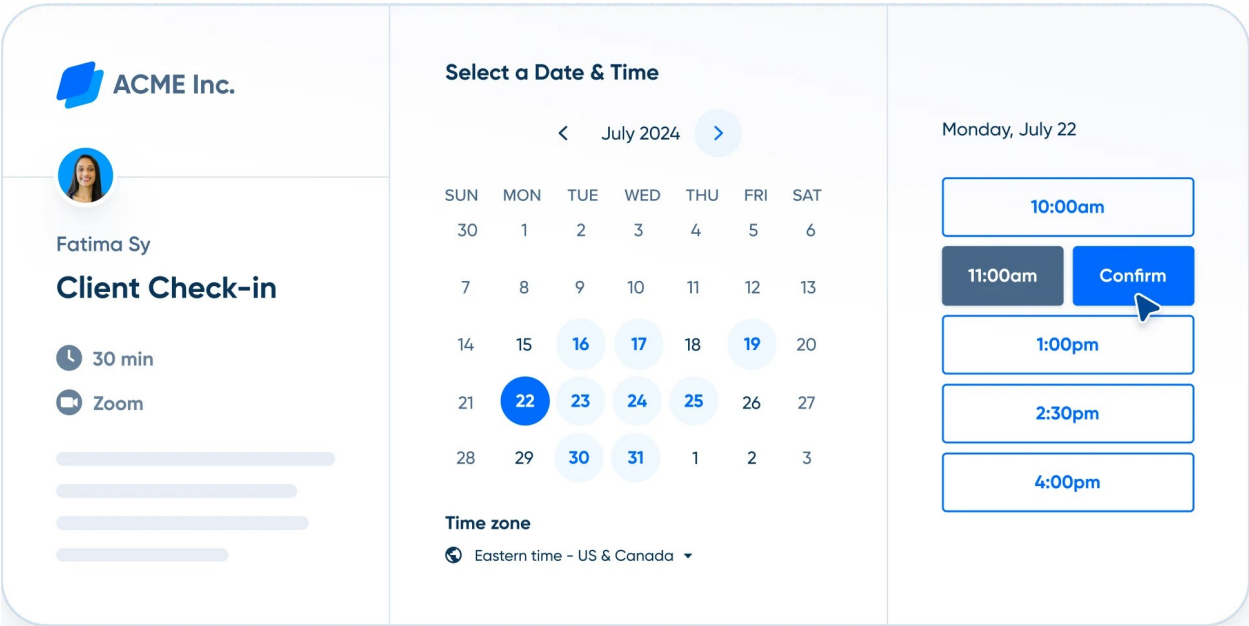
Together they cover the full spectrum of approaches currently used in the market.

Each tool was evaluated across the following dimensions: core user flow, key feature set, strengths, and weaknesses. Findings were then cross-referenced to identify gaps and opportunities for our platform.

2. Tool-by-Tool Findings

2.1. Calendly

Individual-first scheduling automation



Pricing model	Freemium SaaS — Free / \$10 / \$16 per user/month (annual)
Primary target	Freelancers, sales teams, recruiters, service businesses

Core user flow	Host shares a booking link → invitee picks an available slot → event auto-added to both calendars
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Key Features

- Unlimited shareable booking pages (Standard tier+)
- Two-way sync with Google, Outlook, and Apple Calendar
- Round-robin and collective scheduling for teams (Teams tier)
- Automated email/SMS reminders and follow-ups
- Routing forms to qualify and assign leads
- CRM integrations: Salesforce, HubSpot, Marketo
- Video auto-link generation: Zoom, Google Meet, Microsoft Teams
- Payment collection via Stripe and PayPal
- Embeddable booking widget for websites
- Analytics: booking rates, popular times, invitee funnel

✓ Strengths	✗ Weaknesses
• Market-leading UX — polished, fast, and trusted by enterprise customers • Most comprehensive integration ecosystem of any scheduler • Timezone auto-detection is seamless; invitees always see their local time • Routing forms enable complex qualification workflows before booking • Strong brand recognition reduces invitee hesitation on cold outreach	• Expensive at team scale — \$16/user/month for Teams; enterprise pricing on request • Free tier heavily restricted: only 1 event type, 1 calendar connection • Group polling limited to simple Yes/No — cannot capture 'if need be' nuance • No self-hosting option; all data is on Calendly's infrastructure • No custom domain support on any plan • Heavy UI can feel overkill for simple group coordination

2.2. Doodle

Group coordination and availability polling

The screenshot shows the Doodle interface for a group poll. At the top, there's a header with the Doodle logo, a 'Schedule an event' button, a 'My polls' link, and the user's name 'Michael Woodward'. Below this is a message: 'If none of these work for you, please use the Comment section at the bottom of this form to suggest a more convenient time. Thanks, Michael'. There are three tabs: 'Table view', 'Calendar view', and 'Administration'. The 'Calendar view' is selected. The poll is for 'March 2015' and shows three dates: Mon 23, Tue 24, and Wed 25. The time slots are: 7:00 AM - 9:00 AM, 9:00 AM - 11:00 AM, 11:00 AM - 1:00 PM, 1:00 PM - 3:00 PM, 3:00 PM - 5:00 PM. The participants are Debbie, Kelly, Kacey, and Michael. The poll results show that Debbie and Kelly are available for most slots, while Kacey is only available for the 7:00 AM - 9:00 AM slot on Mon 23. Michael is the organizer and has a blue bar at the bottom of the calendar grid. At the bottom, there's a 'Final Dates' dropdown, a 'Save' button, and a 'Cannot make it' button.

	Mon 23	Tue 24	Wed 25
7:00 AM - 9:00 AM	1	2	1
9:00 AM - 11:00 AM	3	3	2
11:00 AM - 1:00 PM	1	3	2
1:00 PM - 3:00 PM	1	3	2
3:00 PM - 5:00 PM	1	3	2

Pricing model	Freemium SaaS — Free (ad-supported) / \$6.95 / \$8.95 per user/month
Primary target	Cross-organizational groups, HR scheduling, informal team coordination
Core user flow	Organizer proposes multiple time slots → participants vote Yes/No/If-need-be → organizer reads results and manually confirms

Key Features

- Group availability polls with Yes / No / If-need-be responses
- No account required for participants
- Google Calendar, Outlook, and iCal sync
- 1-on-1 booking pages (basic, added post-2022)
- Video integration: Zoom, Teams, Google Meet (Pro+)
- Email reminders for polls
- Zapier integration for automation
- Team admin panel and usage reporting (Team plan)
- Ad-free experience on paid plans

✓ Strengths	✗ Weaknesses
- Best-in-class group polling UX — the heatmap view is immediately understandable - No account required for participants; lowest friction of any scheduler 'If need be' response option captures real intent better than a binary yes/no - Works seamlessly for cross-organization scheduling where calendar access is not shared - Lowest entry price for a paid plan (\$6.95/user/month)	- Polling does not automatically book — organizer must manually confirm and send calendar invites - No automated reminders for the confirmed booking (only for the poll itself) 1-on-1 booking pages are basic and lack the polish of Calendly - Free tier shows display ads, which looks unprofessional for business use - No round-robin, routing forms, or CRM integrations - Timezone handling has occasional inconsistencies reported by users - No recurring meeting creation natively

2.3. When2meet

Ultra-simple visual availability grid

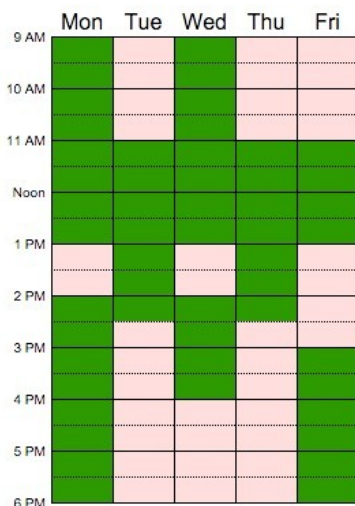
About When2meet Plan a New Event

UID group meetings

To invite people to this event, you can [email them](#), send them a [Facebook message](#), or just direct them to <http://when2meet.com/?4255886-gKf2L>

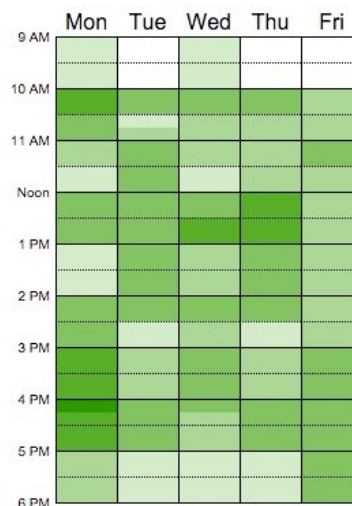
Elena Glassman's Availability

Unavailable Available
Click and Drag to Toggle; Saved Immediately



Group's Availability

0/7 Available 5/7 Available
Mouseover the Calendar to See Who Is Available



Pricing model	Completely free — runs on display advertising and voluntary donations
Primary target	Students, informal groups, academic teams, one-off event coordination
Core user flow	Organizer creates a date/time grid → shares link → participants drag to mark availability → heatmap shows the best overlap

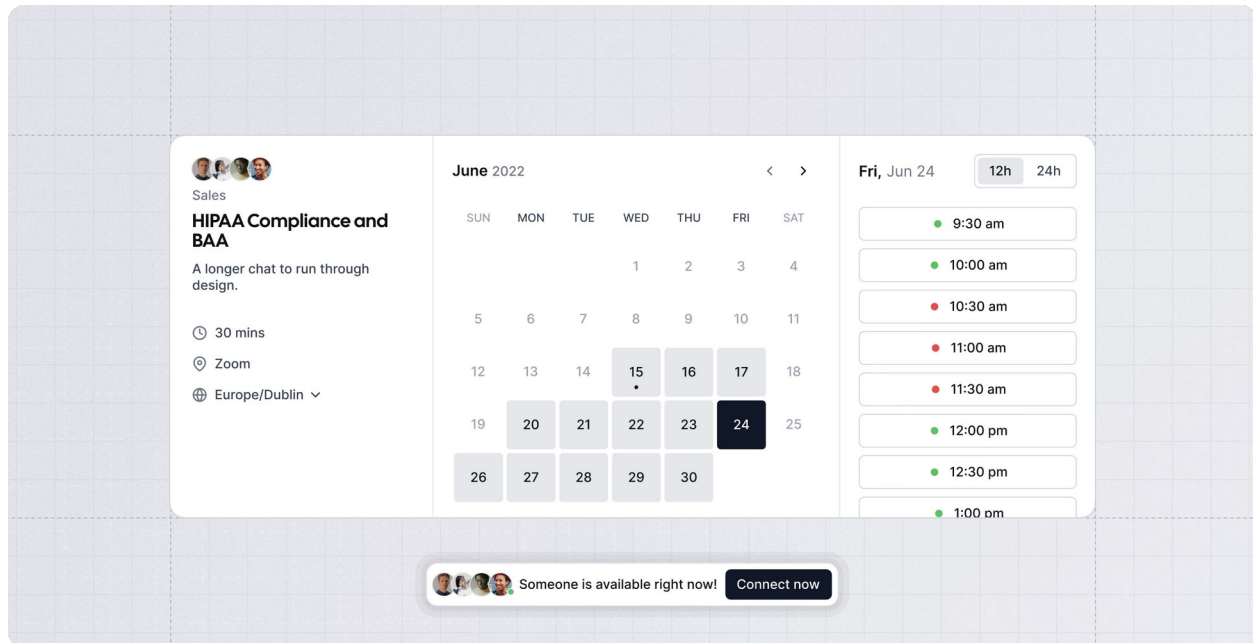
Key Features

- Visual drag-to-fill availability grid
- Color-coded heatmap showing participant overlap
- No account required for organizer or participants
- Two grid modes: specific date range or recurring weekly pattern
- Automatic saving with no manual submit needed
- Participant name list alongside the grid
- 15-minute interval granularity
- Completely free — no plans, no paywalls

✓ Strengths	✗ Weaknesses
• Zero barrier to entry — no account, no download, no payment, ever • Heatmap is instantly readable: best time is visually obvious • Works for any group size with no per-seat cost • Under 2 minutes from start to shared link • No personal data collected, appealing for privacy-conscious users • Surviving and thriving since the mid-2000s — extreme reliability for a free tool	• No calendar integration — participants must manually check their calendar and fill in the grid • Desktop-only UI — drag-to-select grid is awkward on mobile (small targets, no swipe support) • No automated reminders, notifications, or booking confirmation • No 1-on-1 booking pages — purely a polling tool, not a full scheduler • Once the best time is identified, organizer must manually send calendar invites • Interface essentially unchanged since launch; looks dated and informal • Assumes all participants share a single timezone in 'days of the week' mode • No branding, customization, or white-labeling possible • Financed entirely by ads — no guarantee of long-term product investment

2.4. [Cal.com](#)

Open-source, API-first scheduling infrastructure



Pricing model	Freemium SaaS — Free (unlimited event types) / \$12 / \$28 per user/month (annual). Self-host via Cal.diy (community edition, open-source)
Primary target	Developers, SaaS teams embedding scheduling into their own product, privacy-conscious organizations needing data control
Core user flow	Host creates booking page or embeds widget → invitee picks a slot → event auto-confirmed with calendar invite and video link; full API for custom flows

Key Features

- Unlimited event types and bookings on the free tier (no per-seat cap)
- Full public REST API — scheduling as programmable infrastructure
- Self-hosting via Cal.diy (community open-source edition, launched 2026)
- Embeddable booking widget — put scheduling natively inside your own app
- Round-robin and weighted round-robin team scheduling
- Collective scheduling (multiple hosts required for one slot)
- Cal Video — built-in native video conferencing, no third-party needed
- Workflow automation (reminders, follow-ups, webhooks)
- Stripe and PayPal payment collection
- White-label support — remove all Cal.com branding (Teams tier+)
- Custom domain support (Organizations tier)
- SOC2 and HIPAA compliance (Organizations tier)

- Routing forms for lead qualification and assignment
- Google, Outlook, Apple Calendar sync; Exchange connection available

✓ Strengths	✗ Weaknesses
• Most generous free tier in the market — unlimited event types, bookings, and calendar connections at \$0 • API-first design makes it the only tool in this list genuinely suited to embedding scheduling inside your own product • Self-hosting path (Cal.diy) removes per-seat costs and gives complete data ownership • White-label available at the Teams tier — not just Enterprise, unlike Calendly • Weighted round-robin is a standout team feature: distributes bookings based on each team member's actual availability percentage • Cal Video removes the dependency on Zoom or Google Meet for video-linked bookings • SOC2 / HIPAA compliance available at lower price points than Calendly • Active open-source community; fast-moving roadmap with transparent development	• In 2026, the main product moved closed source — the open-source self-hosting path is now Cal.diy, a separate community edition not maintained at the same pace • Third-party integration marketplace is smaller than Calendly's; some niche CRM or enterprise tools are missing • Microsoft Exchange / Office 365 calendar sync has documented inconsistency issues reported by users • Advanced features (workflows, routing forms, custom domains) require paid tiers and have a steeper learning curve • In-app onboarding and documentation quality lags behind Calendly for non-technical users • No group availability polling — purely a booking and automation tool; cannot replicate Doodle or When2meet use cases • Cal Video quality is occasionally reported as unreliable compared to dedicated video tools • Organizations tier (\$28/user/month) is the priciest in this comparison for advanced team features

3. Side-by-Side Feature Comparison

The table below maps the same feature set across all three tools. Colour coding indicates availability at any paid plan (green ✓), only on higher tiers or with limitations (amber ⚠), and not available at all (red ✗).

Feature	Calendly	Cal.com	Doodle	When2meet
Free tier	Yes (1 event type limit)	✓ Unlimited event types	Yes (with ads)	Yes — fully free always
1-on-1 booking pages	✓ Best in class	✓ Yes	⚠ Basic	✗ Not available
Group availability polling	⚠ Yes / No only	✗ Not available	✓ Yes / No / If-need-be	✓ Visual grid heatmap
No account for participants	✓ Yes	✓ Yes	✓ Yes	✓ Yes
Calendar sync (Google/Outlook)	✓ Yes	✓ Yes	✓ Yes	✗ No
Timezone auto-detection	✓ Automatic per invitee	✓ Automatic per invitee	⚠ Partial (occasional bugs)	✗ Single timezone assumed
Mobile experience	✓ Full responsive app	✓ Responsive	✓ Responsive	✗ Desktop-only grid
Automated reminders	✓ Email + SMS	✓ Email + SMS (workflows)	⚠ Poll reminders only	✗ None
Auto calendar invite after booking	✓ Yes	✓ Yes	✗ Manual step required	✗ Manual step required
Round-robin team scheduling	⚠ Teams plan	✓ Weighted round-robin	✗ No	✗ No
Video link auto-generation	✓ Yes	✓ Incl. built-in Cal Video	⚠ Pro tier	✗ No
CRM integration	⚠ Paid plans	⚠ Via API / Zapier	✗ No	✗ No
REST API	⚠ Paid plans	✓ Full API (all plans)	⚠ Limited	✗ No
Embeddable widget	✓ Yes	✓ Yes	⚠ Poll embed only	✗ No

Payment collection	⚠ Standard+	✓ Yes (Stripe / PayPal)	✗ No	✗ No
Self-hosting	✗ No	⚠ Via Cal.diy (community ed.)	✗ No	✗ No
White-label / custom branding	⚠ Enterprise only	✓ Teams tier+	⚠ Paid plans	✗ No
Custom domain	✗ No	✓ Organizations tier	✗ No	✗ No
Analytics dashboard	✓ Yes	⚠ Paid plans	⚠ Team plan	✗ No
SOC2 / HIPAA compliance	⚠ Enterprise only	✓ Organizations tier	✗ Not documented	✗ No

✓ = available, ⚠ = partial / paid tier only, ✗ = not available.

Quick-Reference Summary

Use the table below as a one-liner guide for which tool fits which context, and where each breaks down.

Tool	Best used for	Avoid when you need...
Calendly	1-on-1 and team booking automation; CRM-integrated sales/recruiting flows	Group polling beyond yes/no; self-hosting; budget-conscious teams
Cal.com	Dev teams embedding scheduling into a product; orgs needing API control, white-label, or self-hosting	Group availability polling; non-technical teams expecting Calendly-level hand-holding
Doodle	Cross-org group scheduling; situations where participants won't have accounts	Automatic booking confirmation; mobile-heavy participant groups; CRM workflows
When2meet	Quick informal polls among small groups; students and academic contexts	Mobile users; professional impression; calendar sync; any automation

4. Gaps & Opportunities for Our Platform

The following gaps emerged from cross-referencing the three tools. These represent concrete opportunities to differentiate the platform from day one.

Gap 1	1. No tool bridges polling and instant booking in one flow Doodle and When2meet identify the best time but stop there — the organizer must manually send calendar invites. Calendly and Cal.com skip group polling entirely, offering only 1-on-1 booking. A platform that runs the poll and then auto-books the winning slot would eliminate this manual handoff that every user of Doodle and When2meet currently experiences. → Opportunity: Build a 'poll → auto-confirm → send calendar invite' flow as the platform's core differentiator — this gap exists across all four tools studied.
Gap 2	2. Mobile is broken for grid-based availability tools When2meet's drag-to-select grid is widely cited as the primary reason users look for alternatives in 2026 reviews. Small targets, no swipe support, and accidental selections make it nearly unusable on phones — yet most participants open scheduling links from email or chat apps on mobile. → Opportunity: Design availability input as a mobile-native tap-to-select interaction. This alone would outperform When2meet for the majority of real-world use cases.
Gap 3	3. Timezone handling causes recurring confusion across all tools When2meet assumes a single timezone in 'days of the week' mode. Doodle has documented inconsistencies. Even Calendly and Cal.com, which handle individual booking timezones well, have no concept of group scheduling across timezones. Cross-timezone group coordination remains error-prone across all four tools. → Opportunity: Make timezone handling first-class and explicit: show each participant's local time and the organizer's time simultaneously with clear visual labels, with zero ambiguity.
Gap 4	4. Free tiers are ad-polluted, heavily restricted, or disappearing When2meet is fully free but ad-supported with no product roadmap investment. Calendly's free tier caps at 1 event type. Doodle's free tier shows ads that look unprofessional. Cal.com moved its main product closed source in 2026, pushing the open-source self-hosting path to a separate community edition (Cal.diy) with slower development.

	→ Opportunity: A genuinely generous free tier — no ads, no heavy restrictions — combined with transparent open development could capture the word-of-mouth growth that Cal.com built its early user base on.
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Gap 5	5. No single tool covers the full scheduling lifecycle for teams
	Calendly and Cal.com handle 1-on-1 and team booking; Doodle and When2meet handle group availability polling. No tool does both in one product. Teams consistently end up using Calendly for client bookings and Doodle or When2meet for internal coordination — unnecessary context-switching and two separate tools to learn and maintain. → Opportunity: Position the platform as the unified tool: individual booking pages and group availability coordination in a single product with a shared team dashboard.

Gap 6	6. Cal.com's API strength has no UI-friendly counterpart
	Cal.com's full REST API and embeddable widget are genuinely best-in-class for technical teams, but the product requires significant developer effort to unlock its full value. Non-technical teams are underserved — they get the complexity without the API benefits. Calendly's integrations are rich but locked behind higher tiers and do not allow the same level of product embedding. → Opportunity: Build a platform that is API-capable and embeddable from the start, but with a UX that non-technical users can operate without reading documentation.

5. Conclusion & Recommendation

The market is clearly segmented: Calendly and Cal.com own the 1-on-1 booking and automation space (with Cal.com adding API depth and self-hosting); Doodle and When2meet share the group coordination space. None of the four tools does both well. The most valuable opportunity is to design a platform that:

- ✓ **Unifies group polling and 1-on-1 booking into a single product** — eliminating the need to switch tools depending on the meeting type.
- ✓ **Closes the loop automatically after a poll** — by converting the winning slot into a calendar invite without manual steps.
- ✓ **Is genuinely mobile-first** — solving the long-standing problem that grid-based availability tools are unusable on phones.
- ✓ **Handles timezone explicitly and clearly** — a recurring pain point across all three tools.

These findings should be used as direct inputs into the MVP feature definition and prioritization process in the next sprint planning session.

References :

<https://calendly.com/blog/meeting-scheduling-software>

<https://zencal.io/blog-posts/meeting-scheduler-software/>

<https://lunacal.ai/blogs/best-appointment-booking-software>